Two Songs at One Celebration: Simchat Beit HaShoevah and the Joy of the Righteous and the Returning

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On the evening of Tuesday, 29 September 2026, in many neighborhoods of Jerusalem, there was music late into the night: a Simchat Beit HaShoevah in a shul, a yeshiva, a street closed off for dancing. It is a memory of the celebration in the Temple on the nights of Sukkot, the joy of the place of drawing water, of which the Mishnah says, "Whoever has not seen it has never seen joy in his life" (Mishnah Sukkah 5:1).

The Talmud preserves some of the songs that were sung there. One passage stayed with me all through Sukkot 5787.

Two groups, two songs

The Sages taught that at the celebration, some would sing: "Happy is our youth, that did not embarrass our old age." These were the pious and the people of good deeds, who had spent their lives in Torah and mitzvot. And others would sing: "Happy is our old age, that atoned for our youth." These were the penitents, the *ba'alei teshuvah*. And both together would sing: "Happy is the one who did not sin; and the one who sinned, let him return, and He will forgive him" (Sukkah 53a).

Picture it. Two groups of Jews in the same place, on the same night, dancing to the same music. One group thanks G-d for a life without great falls. The other thanks G-d for a life that fell and was lifted. Neither song cancels the other. And then they sing a third song together.

No first-class and second-class joy

It would have been easy for the celebration to divide. The righteous could have danced in one corner and the penitents in another. Or the penitents could have kept quiet, grateful just to be allowed in. The Talmud describes neither. Each group has its own song, sung out loud, and then a shared refrain.

This is the Sukkot after Yom Kippur. Only days earlier, everyone in that place had stood together and confessed. Now everyone dances together. The joy is not rationed by the record. The one who has always been faithful and the one who has just come back stand side by side at the water.

Hillel's words

The same passage records what Hillel the Elder would say when he rejoiced at the celebration: "If I am here, everyone is here; and if I am not here, who is here?" (Sukkah 53a).

The words are puzzling. The commentators read them in more than one way. One reading is that each person must see himself as the one on whom the joy depends: if I show up, the whole celebration is present in me; if I stay away, something is missing that no one else can replace.

Put that beside the two songs. The penitent might think the celebration belongs to the righteous. The righteous might think it belongs to those with a clean record. Hillel says to each person: if you are here, everyone is here. You are not a guest at someone else's joy.

Joy without sleep

Rabbi Yehoshua ben Chananya remembered those nights: "When we rejoiced at the Simchat Beit HaShoevah, we did not see sleep with our eyes" (Sukkah 53a). The Talmud then describes the schedule of the day: the morning offering, prayer, the Musaf, the meal, study, the afternoon offering, and then the celebration through the night. The joy was not an escape from the day's service. It was the crown of it.

On any night of Chol HaMoed, if you go to a Simchat Beit HaShoevah, look around. Some of the dancers have walked a straight road all their lives. Some have come back from far away. Some are somewhere in between and would not want to say which song is theirs. It does not matter. The music is the same, and the last song belongs to everyone.

For the table

1. At the water celebration, some sang, "Happy is our youth"; others, "Happy is our old age, that atoned for our youth."
2. Then everyone sang together.
3. Hillel said: "If I am here, everyone is here."

Sources

- Mishnah Sukkah 5:1 ("whoever has not seen the joy of the place of drawing")
- Sukkah 53a (the two songs; Hillel's words; Rabbi Yehoshua ben Chananya on the nights without sleep)

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